

THE LONG WAIT
Ajit Pawar outside the Vidhan Bhavan in Mumbai

In POINT

June 2022, Shiv Sena leader Eknath Shinde, who was the urban development minister in the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) government led by his party president Uddhav Thackeray, sprung a surprise by walking out with 39 other Sena legislators. He later became the chief minister in a coalition government with the BJP. Ten months later, there is speculation whether the Sharad Pawar-led Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), which is part of the MVA's rainbow coalition, may see another 'Shinde' emerge from its ranks.

A series of statements by the NCP and MVA leadership fuelled rumours implying that a section of the NCP led by Pawar's nephew Ajit Pawar, who is the leader of the Opposition in the state legislative assembly, may rebel and join hands with the BJP to evade action by the central investigation agencies. NCP leaders have heavy stakes in the state's cooperative sector, including many sugar factories and banks.

However, there are indications that a truce may have been struck for now. On April 18, Ajit, who was the deputy chief minister in the MVA government, strongly denied reports that he had secured the support of 40 of 53 NCP MLAs in his bid. "We all belong to the NCP and will continue in the NCP... we will work for the party till we are alive," he claimed. But then went on to add a loaded caveat: "Any decision that will be taken about this (a change in political affiliations) will be done as a party. But now, the party has decided to strengthen the MVA." His uncle—seen as an architect and trouble-shooter of the MVA—too dismissed any reports about Ajit breaking ranks.

Despite these sanctimonious denials, a cloud of suspicion continues to linger over the NCP's future course of action, largely due to a series of statements by the Pawar duo. For instance, while opposition parties took an aggressive position in Parliament seeking a joint parliamentary committee (JPC) probe into the allegations against the Adani Group, Pawar opposed this demand. He, however, softened his stance later. On the very day (April 7) that his uncle made this statement, Ajit went incommunicado. While it was widely speculated that he may have met BJP leaders during this period, Ajit later attributed his absence to a bout of acidity. The two Pawars have taken positions defending Modi after the opposition sought details about his educational qualifications. While opposition parties, including the NCP, have raised doubts about the alleged tampering of EVMs, Ajit virtually gave the machines a clean chit. This has led some senior Congress leaders to claim that this was a way of trying to warm up to the BJP and "recalibrate" their relationship.

Much of these speculations can be attributed to lingering questions over what happened behind the scenes during Ajit's brief palace coup in 2019. He had joined hands with the BJP in a short-lived arrangement that preceded the formation of the MVA government.

These conjectures reached a cre-